

You start off with a family, and can either choose an average, preset family, or build your own. You decide on their natures (neat, active, playful, nice or outgoing), and get started. Each character has six skills he or she can develop—creativity, logic, body, charisma, cooking and mechanical. Everything you do from the start of the game decides what skill is built up.

First up, you have to look for jobs for your “Sims”, and this is achieved via placement ads or via the Internet. Once you have a steady stream of income, you can begin to buy items, and every item you purchase helps develop your Sims character—a new stove will help the Sims cook better meals, and the result would be happier Sims!

Each Sim has some very basic needs—comfort, hygiene, hunger, room, social, fun, energy, and bladder (yes, even a Sim needs to get bathroom breaks). You need to make sure that each Sim’s needs are satisfied, or else you’re likely to end up with a big mess on the floor if you ignore, say, bladder needs, or a dead Sim if you forget to feed one. Lack of fulfilment of the other needs ends you up with depressed Sims, which may stop responding or listening to your commands. Overall, you need to make sure all your Sims are always happy and content.

To fulfil the need for space, you can rebuild and modify your house to provide more space. This is done easily through the interface and is generally a good idea, as more space equals happier Sims and more room to place the stuff you buy for them. Everything a Sim does is very cutely animated, and you can see everything that happens—from a Sim cooking, watching TV or interacting with other Sims.

*The Sims 2* introduced a few more parameters into the gameplay, such as memories, where what happens now will mildly affect a Sim’s growth—such as the death of a loved one! *The Sims 2* also features the ability to build your own neighbourhood, like in *SimCity*, and you can customise everything surrounding your house.